

CITY ON A HILL

**DON'T
GIVE
UP**



LEADER'S GUIDE

CITY ON A HILL

**DON'T
GIVE
UP**



Copyright © 2018 City on a Hill Studio, LLC

All rights reserved. No portion of this book may be reproduced, stored in a retrieval system, or transmitted in any form or by any means – electronic, mechanical, photocopy, recording, scanning, or other – except for brief quotations in critical reviews or articles, without prior written permission of the publisher.

Published in Louisville, Kentucky by City on a Hill Studio. City on a Hill Studio is a registered trademark of City on a Hill Studio, LLC.

Additional copies of this Leader's Guide along with other Don't Give Up study resources may be purchased online at cityonahillstudio.com

Scripture quotations are taken from the HOLY BIBLE:

New International Version® Copyright © 1973, 1978, 1984 by Biblica, Inc. Used by permission. All rights reserved.



Your group is filled with people hanging by a thread, losing faith and short on strength. What do they all need to hear? Don't give up. Using this guide, you will lead your group will encourage one another to cast your concerns on God, trust in his love and timing, and pray for patience and strength.

TABLE OF CONTENTS

Introduction | 6

Week 1 | 20

Keep Believing

Week 2 | 28

Hall of Fame

Week 3 | 36

Throw Off The Weight

Week 4 | 44

Obstacle Course

Week 5 | 52

Run Your Race



INTRODUCTION



hen was the last time you were in a race?

Not long ago, I entered a fifty-mile bike race. Around the forty-two-mile mark, the wind picked up, my water ran out, and every turn of the pedals felt like a struggle. And that's when my help arrived.

Another racer and I had been passing each other back and forth over the past few miles, and he pulled alongside me and asked how I was doing. "I'm struggling! You?" He was struggling too. Together, we pedaled the final eight miles side by side. We didn't talk a lot, but we gave each other just enough support to keep going. We both wanted to quit—or at least take an extended pit stop at a fast-food joint—but wouldn't let the other give up.

When I felt like quitting, when I couldn't go an inch farther, I found encouragement in one who understood my struggle and could remain with me till the finish line.

We all need this help. Every day. Coming alongside us, identifying with our struggle, and saying, "You got this! Keep going!"



Don't give up!"

Too often, I think of encouragement as a soft pat on the back for doing a good job. But Kyle Idleman, in *Don't Give Up*, gives encouragement some teeth.

"Encouragement is a battle cry. It's a call to move, to act, to advance. What kind of words accomplish that? To encourage means, of course, to give courage—to "speak courage into." That's not the same as making someone feel better. It's not patching up a wound but rather putting a weapon in their hands. It's giving them a fresh horse and the will to advance." (13)

The life of faith is a race, and it's not a sprint. It's a marathon. In fact, it's longer than a marathon—it's one of those ultra-marathons that those crazy people on television do. In the ultra-marathon of faith, we need encouragement like we need food, water, and shelter. Where will we find this encouragement?

THE WITNESS OF HEBREWS 11–12

Where do we find such true encouragement for a marathon-long life of faith and endurance? In the witness of the saints throughout God's Story. The author of the Letter to the Hebrews has written this to us:



THEREFORE, SINCE WE ARE
SURROUNDED BY SUCH A GREAT CLOUD
OF WITNESSES, LET US THROW OFF
EVERYTHING THAT HINDERS AND THE
SIN THAT SO EASILY ENTANGLES. AND
LET US RUN WITH PERSEVERANCE THE
RACE MARKED OUT FOR US, FIXING
OUR EYES ON JESUS, THE PIONEER
AND PERFECTER OF FAITH. FOR THE
JOY SET BEFORE HIM HE ENDURED THE
CROSS, SCORNING ITS SHAME, AND
SAT DOWN AT THE RIGHT HAND OF
THE THRONE OF GOD. CONSIDER HIM
WHO ENDURED SUCH OPPOSITION FROM
SINNERS, SO THAT YOU WILL NOT
GROW WEARY AND LOSE HEART.

-HEBREWS 12:1-3

**DON'T
GIVE
UP**



Have you ever recognized the power of these verses? What is this “great cloud of witnesses” that surrounds us—and how do they impart gritty, real-life courage to us today?

This is no ordinary cloud. This heavy, all-encompassing fog is a crowd of people. You don’t see this kind of cloud; you feel it. This cloud of witnesses gives us a powerful picture: a packed-house throng of history’s greatest heroes watching you, cheering for you, calling out to you, “Get up! Keep going! You’re almost there!”

In context, Hebrews 12—which starts with the transition word “Therefore”—encourages based on the truths of Hebrews 11. And Hebrews 11 is a famous chapter we often call the “Hall of Faith.” In it, the author reminds us of the faith and endurance of our forefathers and spiritual mothers.

Noah—who built an ark in faith of God’s words alone

Abraham and Sarah—who left home and family to follow God to an unknown place

Jacob—who tried to run from his problems and found himself wrestling with God

Moses—who refused to let Israel be oppressed and led God’s people to the promised land

Joshua—who simply walked in faith until the walls of God’s enemies fell in a heap



Gideon—whose little army was empowered by an all-powerful God

Nehemiah—who worked day and night to rebuild Jerusalem while surrounded by doubters

Paul—who finished the race, kept the faith, and passed on to us the charge to build the church

These were all witnesses of God's power and goodness to his people in the unlikeliest of scenarios. They were all pressed to their limits, hit the wall of desperation, and had to fight back the temptation to give up. And as a result, they experienced God's deliverance in historic ways.

These witnesses stand for you today. They cheer you on, and they call out to you in specific, tangible encouragements to keep going, keep believing, keep the faith!

The crowd is chanting: Don't give up!

DON'T GIVE UP: A SYLLABUS

To get the most of this *Don't Give Up* experience, we recommend committing to a journey of five weeks. Think of it as your training plan for the endurance race of faith. Over five weeks, you and your small group will have time to watch five videos, study Scripture together, complete the Journal, and even read the entire *Don't Give Up* book if you choose.



The Journal will enable your group to get the most out of the video series. Designed as a thirty-five-day devotional journey, it connects the message of *Don't Give Up* to an in-depth study of Hebrews 11–12. Each day provides grace-centered devotional content and thoughtful discussion questions and exercises. Your group members will bring more to share and deeper reflections when using the Journal with this Leader's Guide.

Here is a syllabus to guide your personal and group time:

<u>VIDEO</u>	<u>THEMES</u>	<u>JOURNAL</u>	<u>BOOK</u>
WEEK 1	KEEP BELIEVING	WEEK 1	INTRO, CHAPTER 1
WEEK 2	HALL OF FAME	WEEK 2	CHAPTERS 2–3
WEEK 3	THROW OFF THE WEIGHT	WEEK 3	CHAPTERS 4–5
WEEK 4	OBSTACLE COURSE	WEEK 4	CHAPTERS 6–8
WEEK 5	RUN YOUR RACE	WEEK 5	CHAPTERS 9–11



LEADING YOUR GROUP

As you prepare to lead your group through this series on the long-distance race of life, it's normal to feel nervous or under-qualified. But remember: The primary qualification for leading this group discussion is merely a desire to run the race and finish well yourself.

Our study will enter some deep waters. But this is an excellent opportunity to let Hebrews 11–12 minister to the deep places of our souls—to meet us where we are, limping and struggling alongside the road. When someone in your group shares a deep hurt, struggles to believe the good news, or resists sharing in depth, consider a few quick principles.

1. Expect difficult people.

We know that everyone is sinful, but it still surprises us, doesn't it? There will always be difficult people. Remember: Difficult people aren't problems to fix; they're people to love.

2. Recognize stages of maturity.

You may have significant diversity in your group—old and young, married and unmarried, all different personality types and interests. Within a single group, you may have five different seasons of life and varying stages of maturity. From the new believer to the struggling Christian to the quick learner, remember to give grace to each person wherever he or she is at.

3. Embrace the complexity.

People are anything but straightforward. The same person in your group can be outgoing and silent, generous and critical, fruitful and foolish—all depending on the circumstances. This is not unusual; it's human nature. Don't rush to conclusions if someone is struggling; situations are often more complex than they seem.

4. Remember your role.

If you're a small-group leader, there's a good chance you—like me—have a genuine desire to solve others' problems or hold their lives together. But you and I can't change anyone. Our role is to create an environment of grace where God can change people.

5. Start with grace.

Several Christian authors describe the process of how people change:

grace + truth + time (in relationship) = change

We create an environment of grace and expect sinners like us to be present. But even when someone is missing the truth, the first word out of our mouths should likely be one of grace. It's a miracle of God every time someone admits sin or lets others into their suffering. We don't exist to judge one another; we exist to point one another to the grace of God. When we have given grace, we can speak God's truth to one another in love (Ephesians 4:15). But this takes time and patience. All these are necessary for true spiritual change.

ASKING GREAT QUESTIONS

When you gather with your group, a familiar and structured pattern of discussion should prove fruitful. After a period of fellowship and settling in, each week will follow a rhythm of conversation and instruction that enables self-discovery, personal application, and deep meditation on God's Word.

The basic flow of these questions mirrors the work of God's truth in our hearts. The approach is gentle, meeting us where we really are—so we will begin with a soft opening question and prayer. Then we must learn the biblical truths—we'll seek to learn the Scriptures through a reading, the teaching video, and basic questions covering content and meaning.

Understanding truth is essential, but God's Word is meant to be experienced and practiced. In the section "Meditation and Application," the goal is transformation through reflection and personal application. This provides the space for the Holy Spirit to root the truth of Scripture deep in our hearts. Lastly, focusing on application recognizes that we must put a new reality into practice right away. We'll finish in prayer, committing the discussion and all its discoveries to God.



Opening Question

You may choose to alter the opening question to fit your group's dynamics. But keep it simple and light-hearted. Starting with "What's your darkest sin?" or "Who can give us a quick overview of the Old Testament?" can be off-putting. Start instead with a question that's easy for people to answer. For a new or shy person in the group, speaking the first time is often the hardest. But speaking up early, on a simple question, enables them to share more deeply later. If you create your own opening question, choose a simple, open-ended question that connects to the week's theme without getting too far ahead.

Scripture Reading

Before starting the video, take a few minutes to read the assigned passage—a portion from the Letter to the Hebrews. Don't worry about explaining too much at this point. The goal is to have the biblical themes of endurance and encouragement in everyone's mind as you watch the video, then you'll dive in later.

Opening Prayer

Prior to starting the video, say a short prayer to commit the time to the Lord. Consider having this prayer—or any other portions—led by another group member to help share the leadership load.

Video

Before each group gathering, test the appropriate video and familiarize yourself with it. The videos are short and practical and should foster immediate reflection and discussion.

Content and Meaning

After reading the Scripture and watching the video, you will begin to help one another understand their content and meaning. Here, we are simply asking questions like “What does it say?” and “What does it mean?” The questions under the heading “Content and Meaning” will help you reflect on the passage along these lines.

Meditation and Application

Once your group understands the content and meaning of the passage and video, you’ll start a deeper-level conversation. The goal here is not information but transformation.

We read and reflect not merely to learn. We read and reflect to experience. In the sections marked “Meditation and Application,” you’re going to be asking questions like “What does it mean for me to obey this passage today?” and “How can I love and enjoy God more as a result of these truths?”



Here, you may want to adapt these questions to the specific needs of your group. You are encouraged to do this! If you do so, be sure to ask open-ended questions like “How is God inviting you to respond?” as opposed to yes or no questions like “Do you believe that God will sustain your journey?” Seek to open up deep reflection on God’s Word and honest, practical application.

Journal

Before wrapping up the gathering, encourage group members to read ahead for next week in the Journal. As you journey through the Journal together as a group, you will better understand and apply God’s grace and your relationships will grow deeper.

Prayer

Take a few minutes to allow several members to pray aloud. Members can pray words of gratitude for profound truths, pray for pressing situations, and pray for one another.

RUN YOUR RACE

One last reminder: As you lead your group through this study, don’t forget to enter and run the race yourself! Often, we really learn something when we have the responsibility of organizing and teaching it. Think of this not as a burden, but as an oppor-

tunity. Dive deeply into the life-giving waters of Hebrews 11–12, and surely others will benefit as well.

Remember that the message of Hebrews 11–12 speaks directly to you as a leader. Moses and Gideon felt unqualified to lead God's people. Abraham and Joshua didn't have a clear path in front of them. Moses and Jacob each had significant sin in their lives when God called them. Nehemiah and Noah felt constant opposition to their work. This is the calling of spiritual leadership!

When you feel discouraged by silence, overwhelmed with others' struggles, or disappointed by an "off night" in your group, remember: God's Word never fails. Trust the Lord and enjoy the process!







KEEP BELIEVING

**SINCE WE ARE SURROUNDED BY SUCH
A GREAT CLOUD OF WITNESSES, LET
US THROW OFF EVERYTHING THAT
HINDERS AND THE SIN THAT SO EASILY
ENTANGLES. AND LET US RUN WITH
PERSEVERANCE THE RACE MARKED
OUT FOR US.**

—HEBREWS 12:1



WEEK 1

This week, we are starting a new curriculum set called *Don't Give Up*. Each week, we'll watch and discuss a short video, read through a passage of Scripture from the book of Hebrews, and discuss how to find encouragement for the long-distance journey of faith.

Before we begin with the Scripture and video, let's start with an easy question.

OPENING QUESTION

> WHEN WAS THE LAST TIME YOU WERE IN A RACE? IT COULD BE AS FAR BACK AS YOUR SCHOOL DAYS. WHAT WAS THE RACE? WHAT WERE THE CONDITIONS? HOW DID YOU FINISH?

READING

Each week, we'll focus on a portion of Hebrews 11–12 along with the video teaching. Hebrews was written by one of the early church leaders to encourage the church in and around Jerusalem to continue in their faith. They had begun their race strong in Christ, but they were facing persecution, discouragement, and constant resistance. In Hebrews 11–12, the author calls

them back to their forefathers in the faith, Old Testament examples of women and men who completed their races.

As you read or hear it aloud, simply try to understand what the passage is saying, and you may want to jot down a few notes in your Journal or own notebook.

> WOULD SOMEONE VOLUNTEER TO READ HEBREWS 12:1-3?

THEREFORE, SINCE WE ARE SURROUNDED BY SUCH A GREAT CLOUD OF WITNESSES, LET US THROW OFF EVERYTHING THAT HINDERS AND THE SIN THAT SO EASILY ENTANGLES. AND LET US RUN WITH PERSEVERANCE THE RACE MARKED OUT FOR US, FIXING OUR EYES ON JESUS, THE PIONEER AND PERFECTER OF FAITH. FOR THE JOY SET BEFORE HIM HE ENDURED THE CROSS, SCORNING ITS SHAME, AND SAT DOWN AT THE RIGHT HAND OF THE THRONE OF GOD. CONSIDER HIM WHO ENDURED SUCH OPPOSITION FROM SINNERS, SO THAT YOU WILL NOT GROW WEARY AND LOSE HEART.

-HEBREWS 12:1-3

OPENING PRAYER

Let's take a moment to pray together that this time of study and discussion would be helpful.

SAMPLE PRAYER:

Father, thank you for this opportunity to gather during a busy week. Thank you for everyone here and for how you're working in each of

our lives, in many unseen ways. Please give us insight into your Word as we gather. Teach us so that we would find true encouragement for our faith and the strength to finish well.

Amen.

VIDEO

This week's video is about 18 minutes, and then we'll discuss.



PLAY WEEK 1: KEEP BELIEVING

CONTENT AND MEANING

Let's start with a few questions about the video content and Hebrews 12.

> ACCORDING TO HEBREWS 11:1-2, WHAT IS THE DEFINITION OF SIN? HOW WOULD YOU PUT THIS INTO YOUR OWN WORDS?

> LET'S LOOK AT THE WITNESS OF ABRAHAM. HEBREWS 11:8 SAYS, "BY FAITH ABRAHAM, WHEN CALLED TO GO TO A PLACE HE WOULD LATER RECEIVE AS HIS INHERITANCE, OBEYED AND WENT, EVEN THOUGH HE DID NOT KNOW WHERE HE WAS GOING." HOW DID THIS TURN OUT FOR ABRAHAM, AND WHAT CAN WE LEARN FROM HIS STORY?



> HEBREWS 12:1 STARTS WITH “THEREFORE.” HOW DOES THIS POINT US BACK TO HEBREWS 11, AND WHAT IS THE OVERALL MESSAGE OF HEBREWS 11?

IN HEBREWS 12:1-3, THE AUTHOR CALLS US TO DO FOUR THINGS:

- “LET US THROW OFF EVERYTHING THAT HINDERS ...”
- “LET US THROW OFF ... THE SIN THAT SO EASILY ENTANGLES.”
- “LET US RUN WITH PERSEVERANCE THE RACE MARKED OUT FOR US ...”
- “LET US ... [FIX] OUR EYES ON JESUS.”

> HOW ARE THESE FOUR PHRASES CONNECTED? GIVE AN EXAMPLE OF HOW SOMEONE MIGHT DO ALL FOUR IN THE MIDST OF A TRIAL OR HARDSHIP.

> TIM SAID HE BROKE OFF THE REARVIEW MIRROR WHEN HE LEFT LAKE DREAMLAND AND NEVER LOOKED BACK. CAN YOU THINK OF A TIME WHEN GOD CALLED YOU BACK TO SOMEWHERE YOU PROMISED YOURSELF NEVER TO RETURN TO, AS HE DID IN TIM’S STORY?

> AS TIM DID WHEN HE INITIALLY MOVED BACK TO LAKE DREAMLAND, WHEN IN YOUR LIFE HAVE YOU WONDERED “WHERE IS THIS GOING, GOD?” HOW DID YOU RESPOND TO NOT UNDERSTANDING



HOW GOD WOULD ORCHESTRATE EVERYTHING TOGETHER?

MEDITATION AND APPLICATION

Now that we have a good understanding of the teaching and this passage, let's go one step deeper. Let's focus on what these truths say for our hearts here and now, and for how we can live.

> THE ORIGINAL READERS OF HEBREWS WERE DISCOURAGED BELIEVERS. THEY WERE GETTING FATIGUED AND LOSING HEART IN THEIR FAITH. THEY WERE FACING PERSECUTION AND WERE TEMPTED TO GIVE UP. WHEN IN YOUR SPIRITUAL LIFE HAVE YOU FELT LIKE THIS? IN WHAT WAYS DO YOU RESONATE WITH THIS DISCOURAGEMENT EVEN NOW?

> WHEN YOU THINK ABOUT "ENCOURAGEMENT," WHAT COMES TO MIND? DOES IT EVER FEEL LIKE AN UNHELPFUL PLATITUDE?

> THINK ABOUT WHEN GOD HAS ASKED YOU TO TRUST IN HIS PLAN, YOU PRESERVED AND DID NOT GIVE UP. TIM PRESERVED IN HIS MINISTRY AT LAKE DREAMLAND AND SAW THE LIVES OF MANY PEOPLE TRANSFORMED. WHAT WERE SOME SPIRITUAL RESULTS YOU WITNESSED FROM YOUR PERSEVERANCE?

> WHAT DO YOU THINK OF THE IMAGE OF HAVING HUNDREDS OF SPIRITUAL HEROES CHEERING YOU ON FROM HEAVENLY GRANDSTANDS?

> IF YOU COULD HAVE COURAGE POURED INTO YOUR LIFE, WHAT WOULD HAPPEN? HOW WOULD

YOU LIVE IF YOU HAD UNLIMITED, CHRISTLIKE COURAGE AND BOLDNESS?

> **WHAT ARE THE THINGS IN YOUR LIFE THAT COULD BE HINDERING YOUR RUN OF FAITH? WHAT SIN MIGHT BE ENTANGLING YOU?**

> **CAN SOMEONE READ HEBREWS 11:8-9?** FROM THESE VERSES, WHAT WOULD IT LOOK LIKE TO LOOK FORWARD TO THE ETERNAL CITY THAT GOD HAS ESTABLISHED FOR ALL HIS PEOPLE? HOW DOES THIS ETERNAL PERSPECTIVE AFFECT THE WAY YOU THINK ABOUT YOUR CURRENT CIRCUMSTANCES?



STUDY JOURNAL

You each have received a Journal to accompany this series. Before we meet next week, I encourage you to complete the first seven days of devotional readings and questions. The seventh day is a review day, so you can reflect on previous days or get caught up if needed. Over the next week, let's each do Week One of the Journal (Days 1-7) and come ready to discuss next time.

PRAYER

SAMPLE PRAYER:

Father, thank you for this message of hope tonight. We pray that we would look to your Scriptures and find courage for the long-distance run of faith. Thank you for giving us the testimonies of Abraham, Moses, and others to inspire us to action. Over the next few weeks, would you encourage us through your Word and one another, so that we can stay in the race and finish well?

In Jesus's name, amen.



TWO



HALL OF FAME

**THESE WERE ALL COMMENDED
FOR THEIR FAITH, YET NONE OF THEM
RECEIVED WHAT HAD BEEN PROMISED.**

—HEBREWS 11:39



WEEK 2

This week, we are continuing our curriculum set called *Don't Give Up*. Each week, we're watching and discussing a short video, reading through a passage from Hebrews, and discussing how to find encouragement for the long-distance journey of faith.

OPENING QUESTION

> WHEN YOU WERE GROWING UP, WHO DID YOU LOOK UP TO? MAYBE IT WAS A PRO ATHLETE, MOVIE STAR, ASTRONAUT, OR PRESIDENT—PERHAPS EVEN A FAMILY MEMBER. WHAT QUALITIES DID THEY POSSESS THAT YOU WANTED TO GROW INTO?

READING

Each week, we're focusing on a portion of Hebrews 11–12 along with the video teaching. In these chapters, the author calls discouraged believers to remember spiritual heroes who had gone before them, so that they might find fresh courage for their walk of faith.

As you read or hear it aloud, simply try to understand what the passage is saying, and you may want to jot down a few notes in your Journal or own notebook.

> WOULD SOMEONE VOLUNTEER TO READ HEBREWS 11:35-38?

*THERE WERE OTHERS WHO WERE TORTURED, REFUSING TO BE RELEASED
SO THAT THEY MIGHT GAIN AN EVEN BETTER RESURRECTION. SOME
FACED JEERS AND FLOGGING, AND EVEN CHAINS AND IMPRISONMENT.
THEY WERE PUT TO DEATH BY STONING; THEY WERE SAWED IN TWO;
THEY WERE KILLED BY THE SWORD. THEY WENT ABOUT IN SHEEPSKINS
AND GOATSKINS, DESTITUTE, PERSECUTED AND MISTREATED-THE
WORLD WAS NOT WORTHY OF THEM. THEY WANDERED IN DESERTS
AND MOUNTAINS, LIVING IN CAVES AND IN HOLES IN THE GROUND.*

-HEBREWS 11:35-38

OPENING PRAYER

Let's take a moment to pray for our time together.

SAMPLE PRAYER:

*Father, thank you for each and every person here. We have come
together to learn and grow, and we want to become more like your
Son, Jesus. In his name we pray.*

Amen.



VIDEO

This week's video is about 15 minutes, and then we'll discuss.



PLAY WEEK 2: HALL OF FAME

CONTENT AND MEANING

Let's start with a few questions about the video content and Hebrews 11.

> HEBREWS 11 IS OFTEN CALLED THE HALL OF FAITH OR HALL OF FAME. MUCH LIKE A SPORTS OR MUSIC HALL OF FAME, IT'S A PLACE OF HONOR RESERVED FOR PAST HEROES IN THAT PARTICULAR FIELD.

NOAH, ABRAHAM AND SARAH, JACOB, MOSES, GIDEON, SAMUEL, DAVID, AND NEHEMIAH ARE JUST A FEW EXAMPLES. WHO STANDS OUT TO YOU AMONG THE GREAT EXAMPLES OF FAITH FROM THE OLD TESTAMENT? WHAT STORIES HAVE MOST IMPACTED YOUR FAITH?

> OUR PASSAGE (HEBREWS 11:35–38) DESCRIBES ALL THE SPIRITUAL HEROES WHOSE NAMES WE DON'T KNOW. WHAT DID THEY HAVE IN COMMON? WHY DO THEY STAND AS WITNESSES TO THE FAITHFULNESS OF GOD?

> WHY DOES OUR PASSAGE SAY “THIS WORLD WAS NOT WORTHY OF THEM”?

> JENNY'S TUMBLING ACCIDENT CAUSED A LOSS OF INDEPENDENCE AND COMPLETELY CHANGED HER WORLD. CAN YOU RECALL A SITUATION OR INCIDENT IN YOUR LIFE THAT SEEMINGLY FLIPPED EVERYTHING UPSIDE-DOWN FOR YOU?

IN THE VIDEO, KYLE DESCRIBES A COMMON "VICTIM MENTALITY" THAT CAN OVERCOME US. HE SAID WE MIGHT HAVE A VICTIM MENTALITY IN AN AREA OF LIFE IF ONE OF THESE THINGS IS TRUE OF US:

- WHINE AND COMPLAIN—WE LAMENT OUR CIRCUMSTANCES.
- BLAME AND CRITICIZE—WE BLAME GOD AND OTHERS FOR OUR CHALLENGES.
- BECOME CYNICAL AND PESSIMISTIC—WE REFUSE TO HAVE HOPE AND INSTEAD PRACTICE SELF-PITY.

> WHY IS IT SO EASY FOR PEOPLE TO DEVELOP A VICTIM MENTALITY? HOW DOES HEBREWS 11:35–38 GIVE US PERSPECTIVE TO BECOME LESS FOCUSED ON OURSELVES AND MORE FOCUSED ON THE KINGDOM?

MEDITATION AND APPLICATION

Now that we have a good understanding of the teaching and this passage, let's go one step deeper. Let's focus on what these truths say for our hearts here and now, and for how we can live.

> THINK ABOUT THE SWIMMER FLORENCE CHADWICK. HER FIRST ATTEMPT TO SWIM THE ENGLISH CHANNEL FELL A MILE SHORT BECAUSE



OF FOG, BUT THE SECOND TIME AROUND, SHE PERSEVERED THROUGH THE FOG BY ENVISIONING THE SHORE IN FRONT OF HER. HOW DOES HER STORY OF FAILURE AND TRIUMPH CONNECT WITH YOU? WHAT ARE SOME OF THE THINGS THAT KEEP US FROM FINISHING WELL IN OUR FAITH?

> HOW ARE YOU CHALLENGED AND INSPIRED BY THE EXAMPLES OF THOSE WHO WERE THREATENED, MOCKED, TORTURED, IMPRISONED, AND EVEN KILLED FOR THEIR FAITH?

> JENNY SAYS THAT SHE WASN'T MAD AT GOD AFTER HER ACCIDENT SINCE SHE DID NOT THINK A 'GOOD CHRISTIAN' SHOULD BE ANGRY WITH GOD. WHAT DO YOU THINK OF THIS STATEMENT? HAVE YOU EVER FELT THIS WAY?

> WHAT CHALLENGES ARE YOU FACING TODAY? IT COULD BE A RECENT LOSS, A LONG-STANDING TRAUMA, OR A FORM OF RELATIONAL PAIN. HOW HAVE YOU SEEN GOD MEET YOU IN YOUR PAIN AND STRUGGLE? HOW DO YOU SENSE HIM INVITING YOU TO TRUST HIM EVEN MORE DEEPLY?

> WHICH OF THE "SYMPTOMS" OF A VICTIM MENTALITY CAN YOU MOST RELATE TO—COMPLAINING, BLAMING, OR BECOMING PESSIMISTIC? HOW WOULD A CHANGE OF PERSPECTIVE HELP YOU SEE BEYOND YOUR SITUATION?

> IN THE VIDEO, KYLE SAYS, "THE TRUTH IS, LIFE IS DIFFICULT FOR EVERYONE. SOME CHOOSE TO BE DEFEATED. OTHERS CHOOSE TO OVERCOME. INTERESTINGLY, IT'S OFTEN THE PEOPLE WHO HAVE FACED THE MOST DIFFICULTY WHO SUCCEED



THE MOST WILDLY.” HOW DO YOU THINK YOUR CHALLENGES AND DIFFICULTIES COULD BE THE KEY TO YOUR LONG-TERM SPIRITUAL GROWTH?

> JENNY STATES THAT SHE HAS HAD SO MANY DOORS OPENED TO HER AND HAD SO MANY AMAZING EXPERIENCES BECAUSE OF HER SITUATION. DO YOU BELIEVE GOD CAN TRULY USE THE WORST MOMENTS IN OUR LIFE TO PROVIDE OPPORTUNITIES IN OUR FUTURE? CAN YOU PROVIDE AN EXAMPLE OF A TIME YOU’VE SEEN IT IN YOUR LIFE OR SOMEONE ELSE’S LIFE?



STUDY JOURNAL

Before we meet next week, I encourage you to complete the next seven days of devotional readings in Week Two of the Journal (Days 8–14) and come ready to discuss next time.

PRAYER

SAMPLE PRAYER:

Father, we praise you and thank you that you never leave or forsake us. Even when we are made to suffer, and all hope seems lost, you are with us still. And we put our hope not in this world, but in the world to come. May we experience the resurrection to new life that is promised to all who believe in Christ. We love you and trust you.

Amen.





THROW OFF THE WEIGHT

**LET US THROW OFF EVERYTHING THAT
HINDERS AND THE SIN THAT SO EASILY
ENTANGLES.**

—HEBREWS 12:1



WEEK 3

This week, we are continuing our curriculum set called *Don't Give Up*. Each week, we're watching and discussing a short video, reading through a passage from Hebrews, and discussing how to find encouragement for the long-distance journey of faith.

OPENING QUESTION

> WHAT IS THE MOST PHYSICALLY DEMANDING THING YOU HAVE EVER DONE? HAVE YOU EVER RUN A LONG RACE, HIKED UP A MOUNTAIN, COMPLETED A MARTIAL ARTS PROGRAM, OR TRAINED IN THE MILITARY? WHAT WERE THE THINGS YOU HAD TO CUT AWAY OR THROW OFF (BAD HABITS, EXTRA SUPPLIES, ETC.) TO STAY FOCUSED ON YOUR GOAL?

READING

Each week, we're studying Hebrews 11–12, and we'll read a short passage before getting into the video teaching. Tonight, we're returning to Hebrews 12:1–2 and looking at a different aspect of its message.



> WOULD SOMEONE VOLUNTEER TO READ HEBREWS 12:1-2?

*THEREFORE, SINCE WE ARE SURROUNDED BY SUCH A GREAT CLOUD
OF WITNESSES, LET US THROW OFF EVERYTHING THAT HINDERS
AND THE SIN THAT SO EASILY ENTANGLES. AND LET US RUN WITH
PERSEVERANCE THE RACE MARKED OUT FOR US, FIXING OUR EYES
ON JESUS, THE PIONEER AND PERFECTER OF FAITH.*

- HEBREWS 12:1-2

OPENING PRAYER

Let's take a moment to pray for our time together.

SAMPLE PRAYER:

*Father, give us wisdom and insight into your Word tonight. Show us
things in our lives that need to be thrown off or cut away, so that we
can stay focused on you and walk by faith.*

Amen.



VIDEO

This week's video is about 18 minutes, and then we'll discuss.



PLAY WEEK 3: THROW OFF THE WEIGHT

CONTENT AND MEANING

Let's start with a few questions about the video content and Hebrews 12.

HEBREWS 12:1-2 IDENTIFIES AND STATES WE SHOULD GET RID OF TWO COMMON CHALLENGES:

“THROW OFF EVERYTHING THAT HINDERS” (ALSO TRANSLATED “ANY KIND OF WEIGHT”).

“THROW OFF ... THE SIN THAT SO EASILY ENTANGLES.”

> WHAT ARE SOME COMMON THINGS CAN HINDER PEOPLE FROM FOCUSING ON JESUS? WHAT ARE SOME EXAMPLES OF SIN THAT CAN ENTANGLE PEOPLE AS THEY SEEK TO WALK IN FAITH?

> LIKE A RUNNER CHOOSING LIGHTWEIGHT SHOES OR A SWIMMER REDUCING DRAG FROM LOOSE CLOTHES, WE NEED TO GET RID OF THINGS THAT WEIGH US DOWN AND HOLD US BACK. PRIDE IS ONE



OF THE MOST COMMON THINGS THAT CAN HOLD US BACK. WHY IS THAT SO? HOW DOES PRIDE AFFECT ONE'S ABILITY TO FOLLOW GOD?

> **FIRST PETER 5:7 SAYS, “CAST ALL YOUR ANXIETY ON HIM BECAUSE HE CARES FOR YOU.”** AS KYLE SAYS, THIS VERSE CAN ALSO READ, “TRANSFER YOUR ANXIETY.” WHAT WOULD IT LOOK LIKE FOR SOMEONE TO TRANSFER THEIR WORRIES OVER TO GOD?

> **CHRIS REMEMBERS, AT THE BEGINNING OF HIS CAREER, TRYING TO BALANCE HIS WORLDLY GOAL IN SPORTS WITH FINDING PURPOSE AND IDENTITY.** CAN YOU THINK OF A TIME IN YOUR LIFE WHERE YOU HAVE EXPERIENCED TRYING TO FIND A BALANCE BETWEEN A WORLDLY VISION AND FINDING PURPOSE, PERHAPS IN A CAREER OR WITH YOUR FAMILY?

> **CHRIS STATES THAT FINDING JOY IN TRIALS AND IN UNFULFILLED PROMISES IN HIS CAREER HELPED PREPARE HIM FOR WHAT HE WOULD GO THROUGH WITH HIS SON.** WHEN IN YOUR LIFE HAVE YOU SEEN GOD USE YOUR PAST TRIALS TO HELP PREPARE YOU FOR SOMETHING YOU WOULD ENCOUNTER LATER IN LIFE?

MEDITATION AND APPLICATION

Now that we have a good understanding of the teaching and this passage, let's go one step deeper. Let's focus on what these truths say for our hearts here and now, and for how we can live.



CONSIDER THE FOLLOWING “WEIGHTS” THAT CAN WEIGH US DOWN AS WE TRY TO RUN OUR SPIRITUAL RACE:

- LIES WE BELIEVE ABOUT OURSELVES
- POSSESSIONS WE FEEL WE MUST HAVE
- SHAME ABOUT OUR PAST
- ANXIOUSNESS ABOUT OUR FUTURE
- UNBELIEF IN GOD’S PLANS OR PROMISES

> WHICH OF THESE HAVE YOU EXPERIENCED? HOW HAS IT KEPT YOU FROM RUNNING AS FREELY AS YOU COULD?

> WHEN YOU THINK ABOUT YOUR FUTURE—YOUR WORK, YOUR RELATIONSHIPS, YOUR FINANCES—WHAT FEARS TEND TO RISE TO THE SURFACE? HOW ARE THESE FEARS AND WORRIES WEIGHING YOU DOWN?

> READ HEBREWS 11:13-16. THE FAITHFUL BELIEVERS IN THE HALL OF FAME ALL TRADED WORLDLY COMFORTS AND SECURITIES FOR ETERNAL REWARDS. WHAT IN YOUR LIFE WOULD BE MOST DIFFICULT TO GIVE UP—HEALTH, FAMILY, SUCCESS, AND SO ON? WHAT WOULD IT LOOK LIKE FOR YOU TO VIEW YOURSELF AS A STRANGER ON THIS EARTH AND LOOK FORWARD TO A BETTER PLACE?

> HOW WOULD “FIXING YOUR EYES ON JESUS” (HEBREWS 12:2) CHANGE YOU THE WAY YOU VIEW



YOUR CIRCUMSTANCES AND PRESENT CHALLENGES?

> THE WORLD OFTEN TELLS US THAT WE NEED TO ADD TO ACHIEVE, BUT CHRIS STATES IT IS OFTEN THE OPPOSITE; SUBTRACTION CAN BE MUCH MORE BENEFICIAL. IS THERE AN AREA OF YOUR LIFE WHERE YOU FEEL GOD CALLING YOU TO SUBTRACT SOME THINGS? WHAT WOULD THAT LOOK LIKE FOR YOU?



STUDY JOURNAL

Before we meet next week, I encourage you to complete the next seven days of devotional readings in Week Three of the Journal (Days 15–21) and come ready to discuss next time.

PRAYER

SAMPLE PRAYER:

Father, thank you for giving us the desire and ability to follow you. Enable us by your Spirit to overcome pride and fear, and let us grow less dependent on the things of this world. Show us how to live for eternity, starting right now.

In Christ's name, amen.





FOUR

A solid yellow vertical bar runs along the left edge of the page.

OBSTACLE COURSE

**WE DO NOT HAVE A HIGH PRIEST WHO
IS UNABLE TO EMPATHIZE WITH OUR
WEAKNESSES, BUT WE HAVE ONE WHO
HAS BEEN TEMPTED IN EVERY WAY,
JUST AS WE ARE—YET HE DID NOT SIN.**

—HEBREWS 4:15



WEEK 4

This is the fourth week in our curriculum set called *Don't Give Up*. Each week, we are watching and discussing a short video, reading in Hebrews, and discussing how we can find encouragement to overcome the many challenges in our lives.

OPENING QUESTION

> WHY DO YOU THINK OBSTACLE COURSES AND CHALLENGES HAVE BECOME SO POPULAR? (THINK OF THE TOUGH MUDDER AND THE SPARTAN RACE, THE TV SHOW AMERICAN NINJA WARRIOR, AND THE POPULARITY OF CROSSFIT.) WHAT DO YOU THINK LEADS PEOPLE TO WANT TO TAKE ON THESE TYPES OF CHALLENGES?

READING

> WILL SOMEBODY VOLUNTEER TO READ OUR PASSAGE, HEBREWS 4:14-16, TONIGHT?

THEREFORE, SINCE WE HAVE A GREAT HIGH PRIEST WHO HAS ASCENDED INTO HEAVEN, JESUS THE SON OF GOD, LET US HOLD FIRMLY TO THE FAITH WE PROFESS. FOR WE DO NOT HAVE A HIGH PRIEST WHO IS UNABLE TO EMPATHIZE WITH OUR WEAKNESSES, BUT WE HAVE ONE WHO HAS BEEN TEMPTED IN EVERY WAY, JUST AS WE ARE—YET HE DID NOT SIN. LET US THEN APPROACH GOD'S THRONE OF GRACE WITH CONFIDENCE, SO THAT WE MAY RECEIVE MERCY AND FIND GRACE TO HELP US IN OUR TIME OF NEED.

—HEBREWS 4:14-16

OPENING PRAYER

Let's take a moment to pray together that this time of study and discussion would open our eyes and soften our hearts to God's grace.

SAMPLE PRAYER:

Father, thank you for this gathering of friends. Tonight, we pray that we would again come to better understand and experience your faithfulness. All your promises eventually come to pass—but often not in our own time. Show us by your Word how we can find confidence in Christ.

Amen.



VIDEO

This week's video is about 20 minutes, and then we'll discuss.



PLAY EPISODE 4: OBSTACLE COURSE

CONTENT AND MEANING

Let's start with a few questions about the video content, Nehemiah's story, and Hebrews 4.

> HOW DO YOU SEE THESE OBSTACLES SHOW UP IN NEHEMIAH'S MISSION TO REBUILD JERUSALEM?

- INDIFFERENCE: "I'M NOT THE RIGHT GUY FOR THE JOB."
- INSUFFICIENCY: "I DON'T HAVE WHAT IT TAKES."
- OPPOSITION: "THERE'S TOO MUCH WORKING AGAINST ME."
- SLOW PROGRESS: "I GAVE IT A SHOT. IT JUST WASN'T MEANT TO BE."

> HOW DID NEHEMIAH OVERCOME THESE OBSTACLES? WHAT WAS HIS SOURCE OF STRENGTH AND COURAGE?



LET'S DISCUSS WHAT HEBREWS 4 MEANS FOR US TODAY.

- > WHAT DOES IT MEAN THAT JESUS IS OUR GREAT AND FINAL HIGH PRIEST?
- > IN WHAT SENSE DID JESUS BECOME WEAK?
- > WHAT ARE SOME OF THE TEMPTATIONS JESUS FACED IN HIS OWN LIFE?
- > WHY IS IT SIGNIFICANT THAT JESUS ENDURED THE SAME TRIALS AND TEMPTATIONS THAT WE FACE—YET DID NOT SIN?
- > **CHERYL FELT AS THOUGH SHE HAD LOST HER LIFE'S PURPOSE WHEN SHE GAVE UP HER FITNESS CAREER AND FINANCIAL STABILITY TO HELP SAVE HER HUSBAND'S RESTATE BUSINESS.** HAVE YOU EVER FELT SIMILAR TO CHERYL? HAVE YOU FELT LIKE YOUR CIRCUMSTANCES HAVE ROBBED YOU OF GOD'S PURPOSE FOR YOUR LIFE?

MEDITATION AND APPLICATION

Now that we have a good understanding of the teaching and this passage, let's go one step deeper. Let's focus on what these truths say for our hearts here and now, and for how we can live.

- > **HOW DO YOU CONNECT WITH NEHEMIAH'S STORY?** HAVE YOU EVER FELT OVERWHELMED AND



UNQUALIFIED FOR A TASK GOD HAS CALLED YOU TO OR LIKE YOU WERE FACING CONSTANT OPPOSITION? HOW DOES NEHEMIAH'S FAITH INSPIRE YOU?

> CHERYL STATES THAT "PERSEVERANCE IS FAITH IN ACTION." HOW DOES THIS STATEMENT MAKE YOU FEEL? HOW HAVE YOU SEEN GOD DEMONSTRATE THIS IN YOUR OWN LIFE?

> THINK THROUGH THESE COMMON OBSTACLES AGAIN. WHICH ONES FEEL MOST PRESENT IN YOUR LIFE?

- INDIFFERENCE
- INSUFFICIENCY
- OPPOSITION
- SLOW PROGRESS

> HOW CAN YOU EMBRACE YOUR OBSTACLES AND PERSEVERE IN PRAYER? HOW DOES NEHEMIAH'S WITNESS TO "KEEP BUILDING" ENCOURAGE YOU?

REFLECTING ON HEBREWS 4:14-16:

- WHAT WEAKNESSES DO YOU FEEL AS YOU THINK ABOUT YOUR LONG-DISTANCE WALK OF FAITH?
- HOW DO YOU THINK JESUS EXPERIENCED THOSE SAME WEAKNESSES?



- HOW DOES HIS INVITATION TO APPROACH HIM INSPIRE YOU TO MOVE TOWARD HIM?



STUDY JOURNAL

Before we meet next week, I encourage you to complete the next seven days of devotional readings in Week Four of the Journal (Days 22–28) and come ready to discuss next time.

PRAYER

SAMPLE PRAYER:

Father, grant us the faith of Nehemiah to embrace our obstacles, overcome the resistance in our lives, and keep building. Thank you for sending your Son to suffer on our behalf, and by his sinless suffering, to make a way for our salvation.

In Christ's name, amen.



FIVE





RUN YOUR RACE

**RUN WITH PERSEVERANCE THE RACE
MARKED OUT FOR US, FIXING OUR
EYES ON JESUS, THE PIONEER AND
PERFECTER OF FAITH.**

—HEBREWS 12:1-2



WEEK 5

This week, we are finishing our series, *Don't Give Up*. Each week, we have watched and discussed a short video, read through a section from Hebrews, and reflected on how to find encouragement for the long-distance journey of faith.

OPENING QUESTION

> THE BIBLE MAKES MULTIPLE REFERENCES TO RUNNING. SEVERAL BIBLICAL BOOKS DESCRIBE OUR FAITH AS A RACE. ALL FOUR GOSPELS MENTION PEOPLE RUNNING AT THE SCENE OF THE RESURRECTION. WHY DO YOU THINK THIS IS THE CASE? WHAT ARE THE PARALLELS BETWEEN RUNNING AND LIVING BY FAITH?

READING

We're finishing this study back where we started, in Hebrews 12:1–3.

> WOULD SOMEONE VOLUNTEER TO READ OUR PASSAGE ALOUD?

THEREFORE, SINCE WE ARE SURROUNDED BY
SUCH A GREAT CLOUD OF WITNESSES, LET US
THROW OFF EVERYTHING THAT HINDERS AND
THE SIN THAT SO EASILY ENTANGLES. AND
LET US RUN WITH PERSEVERANCE THE RACE
MARKED OUT FOR US, FIXING OUR EYES ON
JESUS, THE PIONEER AND PERFECTER OF FAITH.
FOR THE JOY SET BEFORE HIM HE ENDURED THE
CROSS, SCORNING ITS SHAME, AND SAT DOWN
AT THE RIGHT HAND OF THE THRONE OF GOD.
CONSIDER HIM WHO ENDURED SUCH OPPOSITION
FROM SINNERS, SO THAT YOU WILL NOT GROW
WEARY AND LOSE HEART.

-HEBREWS 12:1-3

OPENING PRAYER

Let's take a moment to pray for our time together.

SAMPLE PRAYER:

Father, thank you for the encouragement you have brought through this study. As we wrap up tonight, enable us to keep these truths with us and to put them into practice, living by faith and finishing the race well. In Jesus's name we pray.

Amen.

VIDEO

This week's video is about 20 minutes, and then we'll discuss.



PLAY EPISODE 5: RUN YOUR RACE

CONTENT AND MEANING

Let's start with a few questions about the video content and Hebrews 12.

> WHAT STANDS OUT TO YOU FROM MARLA RUNYON'S STORY OF RUNNING IN THE OLYMPICS WITH LIMITED VISION? HOW DOES THIS ILLUSTRATE THE SPIRITUAL LIFE?



> HEBREWS 12 CALLS US TO RUN WITH PERSEVERANCE THE RACE MARKED OUT FOR US. WHAT DOES THAT MEAN? WHO MARKS OUT THE RACE FOR US?

> DO YOU THINK IT'S TRUE THAT "THE FIRST STEP IS THE HARDEST" IN FAITH? WHY OR WHY NOT?

> CHRIS MENTIONS THAT AFTER THE FIRST AFFAIR HE AND COLLEEN DID NOT REACH OUT FOR HELP, WHICH WAS A BIG MISTAKE. CAN YOU THINK OF A TIME WHEN YOU WERE GOING THROUGH A DIFFICULT TIME, AND YOU DIDN'T REACH OUT FOR HELP? IN HINDSIGHT, WHY DO YOU THINK REACHING OUT, BOTH TO OTHERS AND GOD, IS SO CRUCIAL?

> IN THE VIDEO, KYLE SAYS, "WHEN YOU'RE FACING A FRIGHTENING SITUATION, YOU FIX YOUR EYES ON YOUR SOURCE OF STRENGTH. CHILDREN LOOK TO THEIR PARENTS. PLAYERS LOOK TO THEIR COACHES. CITIZENS TURN TO THEIR LEADERS IN TIMES OF CRISIS." WE, OF COURSE, ARE TO FIX OUR EYES ON JESUS. HOW DOES THAT CHANGE THE WAY YOU THINK ABOUT THIS PASSAGE?

MEDITATION AND APPLICATION

Now that we have a good understanding of the teaching and this passage, let's go one step deeper. Let's focus on what these truths say for our hearts here and now, and for how we can live.



> HEBREWS 12:3 ENCOURAGES US BECAUSE WE MAY EASILY “GROW WEARY AND LOSE HEART.”

WHERE IN YOUR LIFE DO YOU FEEL SPIRITUALLY FATIGUED? IN WHAT AREAS DOES YOUR HEART FEEL DISCONNECTED OR DISCOURAGED?

> WHEN CHRIS BEGAN TO MAKE CHANGES IN HIS LIFE ONCE HE MOVED OUT, COLLEEN SAID SHE KNEW THE CHANGES COULD HAVE ONLY COME FROM THE LORD. HAVE YOU EVER EXPERIENCED THIS YOURSELF? IF YOU ARE WILLING, SHARE A TIME WHEN YOU SAW A CHANGE IN SOMEONE ELSE OR YOURSELF THAT COULD ONLY BE EXPLAINED BY GOD’S WORK WITHIN THEIR/YOUR LIFE.

> ONE OF THE LAST PIECES OF ADVICE THAT COLLEEN GIVES IS TO ALWAYS BE ON WATCH FOR THE LORD AND STAY IN THE WORD. WHY DO YOU THINK STAYING IN THE WORD DURING DIFFICULT AND TROUBLING TIMES IS SO IMPORTANT?

> A PERSONAL TRAINER MIGHT TELL SOMEONE STRUGGLING WITH MOTIVATION TO “JUST SHOW UP.” IN THE SAME WAY, OUR SPIRITUAL LIVES REQUIRE US TO SHOW UP EVEN WHEN WE DON’T FEEL LIKE IT. WHAT CONSISTENT RHYTHMS OF SHOWING UP DO YOU THINK WOULD HELP YOUR SPIRITUAL LIFE?

> IN JOHN 16:33, JESUS SAYS, “IN THIS WORLD, YOU WILL HAVE TROUBLE. BUT TAKE HEART! I HAVE OVERCOME THE WORLD.” HOW DOES THIS MOTIVATE AND ENCOURAGE YOU FOR TODAY’S CHALLENGES AND TOMORROW’S FEARS?



> LOOKING BACK OVER THE LAST FIVE WEEKS, HOW HAVE YOU BEEN MOST ENCOURAGED TO KEEP RUNNING, TO NOT GIVE UP, AND TO FINISH STRONG?



STUDY JOURNAL

I encourage you to complete the last seven days of devotion-al readings and questions in Week Five of the Journal (Days 29–35), as we wrap up this series.

PRAYER

SAMPLE PRAYER:

Father, thank you for leading us and moving us to courage and action through your Word. Thank you for the countless women and men of faith in the Scriptures who cheer us on in the faith. Give us the confidence to approach you through Christ, so that we can continue to run the race marked out for us. Let us fix our eyes on Jesus. We pray in his name.

Amen.





ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Jeremy Linneman

Jeremy Linneman, M.A., is teaching pastor of Trinity Community Church in Columbia, Missouri. Prior to planting Trinity, he served as a staff pastor of Sojourn Community Church in Louisville, Kentucky, for seven years.

He is the author of *Life-Giving Groups: How to Grow Healthy, Multiplying Community Groups*, and three other study journals for City on a Hill Studios: *Grace is Greater, I Can Only Imagine*, and *The End of Me*. His articles and resources are available at jslinneman.com. He and his wife, Jessie, have three sons and spend most of their free time outdoors.



The Leader's Guide is designed to facilitate meaningful discussion when using the Series within a group setting. It is easy to follow and includes helpful tips on how to lead a small group.

